

SECESSION TRIGGERS WAR 1861

Despite last-ditch attempts to work out a political compromise, the first months of 1861 saw a steady disintegration of relations between North and South and between the political leaders of the two sections. By early February, seven states had seceded from the Union and taken steps toward establishing the Confederacy. President Abraham Lincoln continued to maintain that conflict was unnecessary, but the reality was that positions were hardening every day. Across the South, the seceded states started taking over Federal outposts. Not surprisingly, one of these confrontations between Southern forces and troops loyal to the Union erupted in violence—at Fort Sumter in Charleston Harbor, on April 12.

With the nation's small prewar armed forces divided between the two sections, neither at first had the means to fight the other on any significant scale. Both sides began assembling volunteer armies and based their recruitment on calls that emphasized principled outrage over the perceived iniquity of their opponents, a process that could only deepen the divide.

Initially, the Southern forces had the advantage of fighting on home territory, being able to meet logistical challenges, such as transporting men and arms, more easily, and having enslaved men to do much of the unpleasant work that a large army requires. The North had important advantages—more people, more money, and far more industrial power—but it was thought that the South could simply outlast the Northern will to fight. These strategic realities meant that the war was unlikely to be decided quickly. At the start, the South was better served by its generals than the North, and the Confederacy was made safe for the moment on land. On the Confederacy's coast and its rivers, however, the Union's resources promised success.

